

Keeping Up with AI

Where the technology actually stands today — and why, technical or not, it's a good moment for anyone to start building.

Sébastien Martin

Associate Professor of Operations · Northwestern Kellogg
ANHW Chicago & HKS Alumni · June 9, 2026

A QUICK INTRODUCTION

Sébastien Martin

Background

- From Paris, France
- PhD in Operations Research
- Associate Professor of Operations



Teaching

- AI Foundations for Managers — AgentOps
- Operations Management

Research — AI & algorithms in Operations



- Advising PhD students



Keeping Up with AI

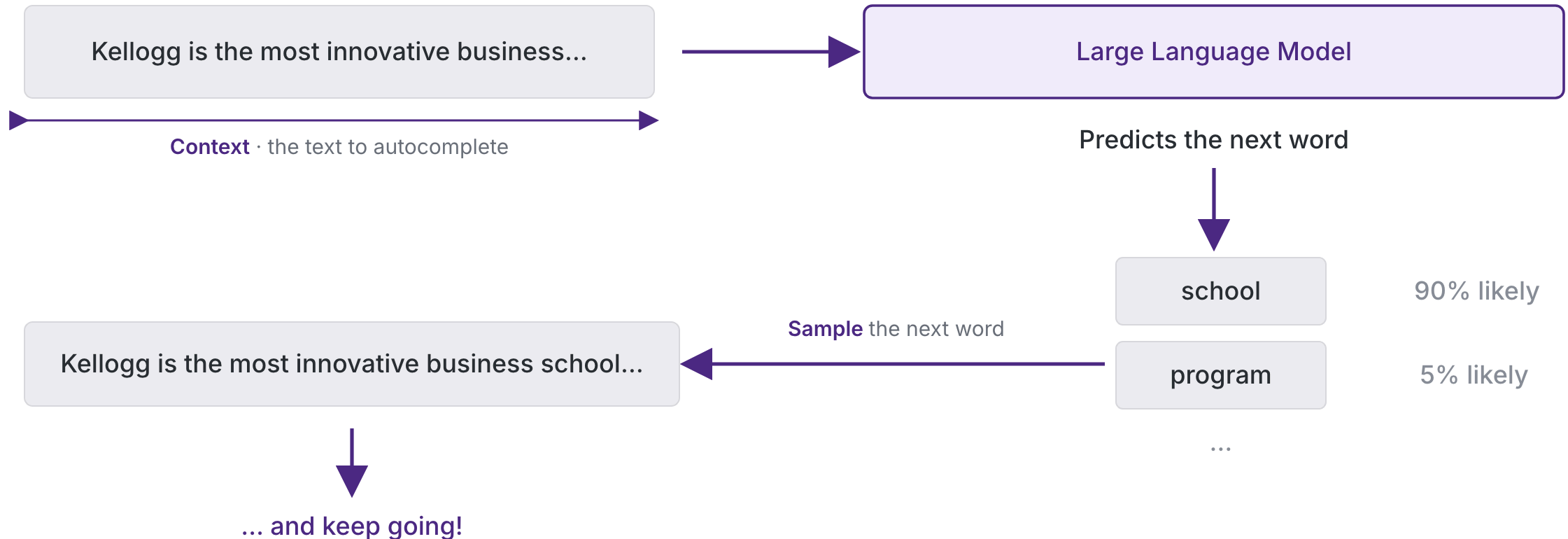
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Understanding the AI state of the art

Large Language Models: a fancy "autocomplete"



THE LAST FOUR YEARS

From ChatGPT to Claude Cowork



THE TECHNOLOGY IS MOVING SO FAST

So what should we do?

There are no AI experts — and everybody can become one.

There is no doubt that it will be transformative.

Use it, use it, use it.

Building with AI

*Demo: the unreasonable power of
computer agents* (Claude
Cowork)

BUILT LIVE

The AI assistant I built in one minute

sebastienmartin.info/p/kai



Scan to try it yourself

SO FAR

The takeaways

AI's progress is accelerating.

AI is becoming easier and easier to use and leverage.

Success = 5% AI knowledge, 95% domain knowledge.

Navigating a technology disruption

A REAL DECISION

If you were in my shoes, what would you do?



NYSE: ESAB

Industrial compounder (mostly welding)

~10,000 employees around the world

~\$3 billion yearly revenue

I joined the board in January.

My main focus: their AI strategy.

Based on your experience and intuition, how should the company react to the AI disruption?

IT'S NEVER JUST THE TECHNOLOGY

Great technology doesn't automatically lead to great impact

To leverage a technology, we need to understand it

Navigating uncertainty

What's the value created? How do we measure it?

The rest of the system matters

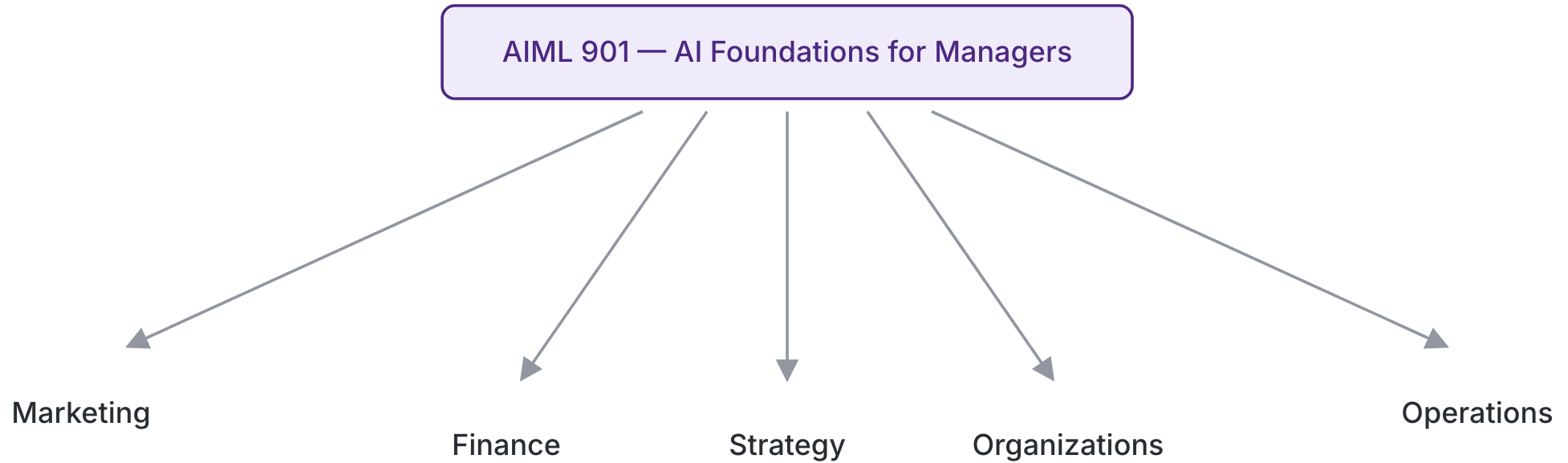
People matter: change management



Introducing robotics in manufacturing took a long time!

AI at Kellogg

Kellogg's AI offerings



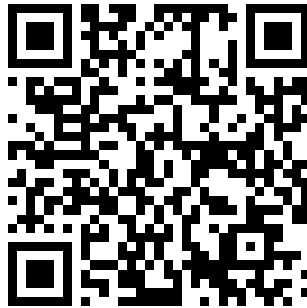
FROM ZERO, NO CODING BACKGROUND

What Kellogg students built in just five weeks

Track medication adherence by texting patients personalized reminders

Track competitor clinical trials to inform pharma strategy

Answer customer questions automatically and route complex ones to experts



Course & projects

Turn course syllabi into study plans with deadlines

Sort and prioritize a travel agency's inbox, flagging urgent requests

Monitor news and alert retail investors when their stocks are at risk

The classic MBA case study



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9-619-003

OCTOBER 1, 2018

CHIARA FARRONATO

ALAN MACCORMACK

SARAH MEHTA

Innovation at Uber: The Launch of Express POOL

The mood was tense in a conference room at Uber's headquarters in March 2018. Two weeks earlier, the San Francisco-based ride-sharing company had launched a new product called Express POOL (Express) in six U.S. cities. Express offered a reduced price to riders willing to carpool, walk a short distance to/from their pick-up and drop-off points, and wait a few minutes before being matched to a driver. The six-city launch followed a December 2017 pilot of the product in Boston and San Francisco.



A typical MBA case study: a long PDF.

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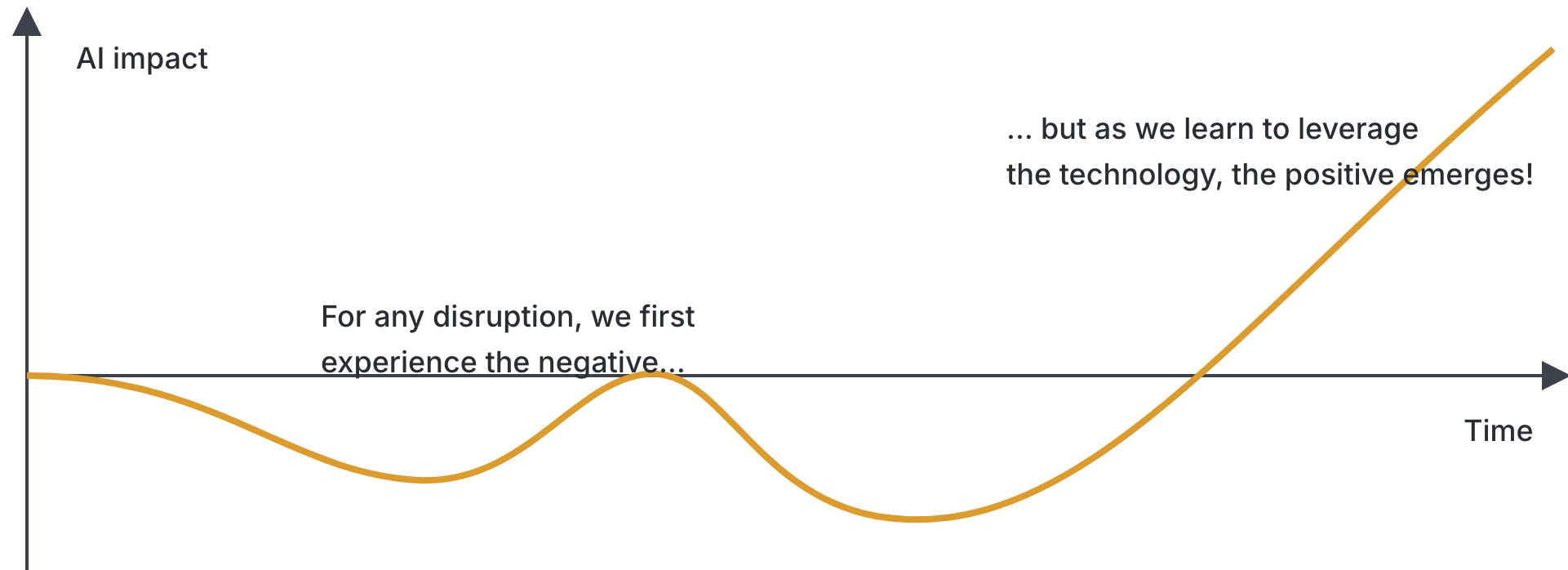
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WHAT TO EXPECT

Every technology disruption follows a curve



ONE LAST PIECE OF ADVICE

Build, build, build

*There are no AI experts — and everybody can
become one.*

Thank you! · sebastienmartin.info